Congress president, he led the party to creditable wins in MP, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan, before it all came crashing down again in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. Though Rahul took the blame for the debacle and stepped down as president, he continued to operate as de facto chief, relying on a small coterie to take decisions. He became a stranger to his own party and partymen, acquiring a reputation for being reclusive and inaccessible, prone to disappearing on foreign sojourns at short notice and remaining at odds with the old guard in the Congress. Soon, even the younger lot, whom he had promoted, be it Scindia, Jitin Prasada, Sushmita Dev or R.P.N. Singh, began deserting him, and it seemed as though Rahul had completely lost the plot.

DISPLAYING THE ABILITY AND STAMINA TO ENDURE A CROSS-COUNTRY YATRA HAS HELPED RAHUL LEAVE BEHIND THE IMAGE OF SOMEONE SEEN AS A DILETTANTE

The Bharat Jodo Yatra has helped him retrieve some of that lost ground. Walking for eight hours daily, mingling freely with thousands of people, Rahul has established a direct connect with the masses. Images of his interactions have been beamed to a million others on their phone or television screens. Come rain, shine or biting cold, he has addressed public meetings. Rahul, in fact, has made it a point to hold press conferences in most states that the BJY has passed through and take questions from reporters, taking care to highlight that this is something Prime Minister Narendra Modi rarely done despite having been in power for nine years now. Taunting the prime minister's preference for one-way communication, a Congress spokesperson said, "Modi speaks his *mann ki baat*, Rahul listens to people's *mann ki baat*." And beating the BJP at its own game, of mounting an aggressive social media campaign, Rahul's team flooded social media with images of him smiling, chatting, waving, hugging overjoyed commoners, taking little children in his arms, and urging local party grandees to go on short sprints with him—the shining head of a billowing comet with a tail of followers, as it were.

In demonstrating the ability, stamina and forbearance to endure the dust and grime of a cross-country yatra, Rahul has managed to take leave of the image of someone who was seen as impatient, fidgety and suffering from an attention deficit. In fact, he said as much in response to a question by a reporter in Haryana—that he had felled the Rahul Gandhi of the old. The Reborn Rahul, overgrown



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

THE ANATOMY OF A YATRA

THE DRILL

- In the early days of the yatra, the team, including Rahul Gandhi, would wake up at 4 am, finish breakfast and start walking by 7 am. In the winter, the schedule has been delayed by an hour
- After four hours, the yatra breaks for lunch and RG takes a short nap, in a separate container. Post-siesta, he visits places, meets people or holds press meets
- At 4.30 pm, the second round begins, often continuing well past sundown

THE INFRASTRUCTURE

- All yatris spend the night in makeshift AC containers—17 ft long, 6 ft wide and 8 ft high—mounted on trucks
- There are 65 containers in all, 60 residential, five used for services such as a hospital, conference room, washroom and electrical unit
- The containers are of four types, depending on the number of beds
- Containers 1 and 2, marked in yellow are reserved for Rahul and Priyanka, when she